



THOMAS SIMONETTI FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Jayden Daniels led a game-winning drive as the Commanders beat the Buccaneers, 23-20, for their first postseason win in 19 years.

Playoff pressure is no problem

Behind Daniels, Commanders win another thriller to advance to the NFL's divisional round



Barry Svrluga

TAMPA — Maybe the best way to encapsulate the 180-degree about-face the Washington Commanders undertook in one NFL season is this: When the team trails and the clock is ticking, the expectation is no longer an inevitable loss. It's an anticipated win. They do not cave. There is only confidence.

So when the Tampa Bay Buccaneers

kicked a game-tying field goal with less than five minutes to go Sunday night, the challenge was there for Washington quarterback Jayden Daniels: Take the ball. Own the moment. Win the game. Again.

Is it too much to reasonably expect from a 24-year-old in his first NFL playoff game? Sure. But the other aspect revealed about this entire operation during its renaissance season is that Daniels isn't normal and what's too much

for most is just fine for him.

That would be Jayden Daniels, stud, hitting Dyami Brown over the middle on one third-down play. That would be Jayden Daniels keeping the ball himself, rushing past the marker on another third-down play. That would be Jayden Daniels orchestrating the drive that led

SEE SVRLUGA ON A10

Inside: With a winning kick, the Commanders are moving on. D1

Rubio's broadsides could roil prospects

His attacks on Tesla, ban from China complicate secretary of state bid

BY MICHAEL KRANISH

When Sen. Marco Rubio escalated his broadsides against the Chinese government over what he called a "grotesque campaign of genocide" against Uyghur Muslims, Beijing responded in 2020 with an extraordinary rebuke: banning the Florida Republican from the country.

Afterward, Rubio not only accelerated his criticism — pushing legislation that banned imports from the Xinjiang region, where China allegedly operated enslaved labor camps — but also attacked Elon Musk's electric car company for opening a showroom in the region.

"Right after President Joe Biden signed Sen. Rubio's Uyghur Forced Labor Prevention Act into law, @Tesla opened a store in #Xinjiang," Rubio tweeted in 2022. "Nationless corporations are helping the Chinese Communist Party cover up genocide and slave labor in the region."

Now Rubio's efforts to aid the Uyghurs could become a focus of his nomination hearing to be President-elect Donald Trump's secretary of state. His human rights advocacy could not only

SEE RUBIO ON A6

A suicide exposes a military struggle

BY ALEX HORTON

The fiery New Year's Day suicide of an Army Green Beret exposed the Pentagon's struggle to identify and treat brain injuries and mental health issues, raising alarm among some lawmakers, medical experts and former military personnel who question if enough is being done to improve care and prevent similar tragedies.

Matthew Livelsberger, 37, a career Special Forces soldier with extensive wartime service in Afghanistan, died of a self-inflicted gunshot moments before the rented Tesla Cybertruck he was driving exploded outside the Trump International Hotel Las Vegas, authorities have said. Liv-

Dramatic death outside Trump hotel underscores toll of invisible wounds

elsberger had struggled with what he endured in combat and confided in an ex-girlfriend that he experienced health problems linked to repeated concussions.

Such invisible wounds can hinder a person's ability to regulate their behavior and lead to substance abuse, insomnia and other serious problems such as suicide, experts say. Recent legislation and Pentagon programs have emphasized screening and self-reporting for such injuries, but crit-

ics cast doubt on whether the Defense Department and individual commanders are moving with suitable alacrity.

A particular concern, they said, is the culture inherent to Green Berets and other Special Operations forces, a high-speed, secretive working environment where Livelsberger spent the majority of his military career. Operators pride themselves on toughness and resiliency, and often elect to gut out mental and physical ailments for fear that acknowledging they need help will put them at risk of being pulled from their duties.

While senior leaders have sought to change that culture, such efforts do not always take

SEE PENTAGON ON A5

As fires rage, Calif. leaders face attacks

TRUMP BLAMES OFFICIALS FOR DESTRUCTION

Musk, allies spread misinformation on disaster

BY MAEGAN VAZQUEZ, MARIANA ALFARO AND BEN BRASCH

As California continues to battle catastrophic wildfires consuming entire neighborhoods and taking lives, state and local officials are also fending off President-elect Donald Trump and his allies' efforts to blame them for the destruction.

At least 24 people are dead and as many are missing as roaring flames ravage Southern California, in what Gov. Gavin Newsom (D) said he expects will be the

worst natural disaster in U.S. history in terms of the scale and scope of damage. There will also probably be "a lot more" deaths added to the fatality toll, Newsom said in an interview that aired Sunday. The number of missing is expected to quickly increase by the dozens as search crews continue their work.

Instead of offering words of sympathy or pledges of rebuilding, Trump, his billionaire ally

SEE FIRES ON A9

Wall Street: BlackRock is the latest firm to ditch a climate coalition. A9



DAVID RYDER/REUTERS

The remains of homes and trees burned by the Palisades Fire dot the Pacific Palisades neighborhood in Los Angeles.

Earlier blaze may have sparked Palisades Fire

BY BRIANNA SACKS, JOYCE SOHYUN LEE, IMOGEN PIPER AND AARON C. DAVIS

LOS ANGELES — About 30 minutes after the Palisades Fire started on Tuesday, the firefighters' radio crackled: The flames were coming from a familiar sliver of a mountain ridge.

"The foot of the fire started real close to where the last fire was on New Year's Eve," said a Los Angeles County firefighter, according to a Washington Post review of archived radio transmissions.

"It looks like it's going to make a good run," one chimed into the

dispatch.

The Post's analysis of photos, videos, satellite imagery and radio communications, as well as interviews with witnesses, offers new evidence that the Palisades Fire started in the area where firefighters had spent hours using helicopters to knock down a blaze six days earlier.

Investigators from state and federal agencies descended on this area in recent days, interviewing residents and looking for evidence — including around the burn scar of the New Year's Eve fire — of what sparked the blaze.

The Post's analysis showed that

SEE PALISADES ON A8

Industry anticipates more green lights for self-driving vehicles

Optimism that Trump administration will pave the way for expansion

BY IAN DUNCAN

LAS VEGAS — After years of hype and overpromises the message from tech industry leaders on the eve of Donald Trump's return to the White House was clear last week: The robot drivers have arrived.

As tens of thousands of nerds and assorted gearheads gathered to marvel at new technology at the annual CES show, huge billboard screens over the Las Vegas Strip heralded the recent deployment of Zoox's strange-looking robotaxi —



CHRIS VELAZCO/THE WASHINGTON POST

A Zoox robotaxi in San Francisco last week. A recent poll found that many Americans are still skeptical of driverless vehicles.

which doesn't have a steering wheel or any other normal controls — proclaiming, "It's not a car."

On the conference stage, the co-founder of the autonomous trucking firm Aurora boasted of performance that was "superhuman." Tekedra Mawakana, a co-chief executive of Waymo, said the company's driverless taxi service was providing 150,000 rides a week by the end of last year, proof that the technology "definitely became real."

With Trump's inauguration approaching — and with Tesla chief executive Elon Musk at his side and betting his own company's future on its robotaxi — the industry's optimism also extends to Washington. Executives viewed officials in Trump's first term as friendly. Now, with vehicles on the

road carrying paying customers, the executives are excited by the prospect of Republicans using their new power to set standards that will help them expand from a handful of cities to communities across the nation.

The Autonomous Vehicle Industry Association, a trade group, last week called for creating common standards, an effort to build public confidence by setting a baseline for safety. It also proposed eliminating safety rules that require steering wheels and pedals in self-driving cars.

But while the push to replace human drivers is being sold on the promise that the robots will be far safer, the public remains deeply skeptical that autonomous vehicles can themselves be trusted. High-profile crashes — including

SEE SELF-DRIVING CARS ON A7

IN THE NEWS

Rubio's replacement Florida Attorney General Ashley Moody is considered the favorite to fill the Senate seat of Donald Trump's pick for secretary of state. A7

Iran on the defensive Already feeling the weight of regional instability, Tehran braces for another Trump administration. A12

THE NATION Joe Biden's economic legacy is in the hands of those who will see benefits years from now. A3
Stephen K. Bannon vowed to limit Elon Musk's influence on Donald Trump. A4

THE WORLD West Africans educated in Russia are playing a central role as Moscow seeks influence in Burkina Faso. A11
Israel is investing in domestic production of heavy weapons. A13

THE ECONOMY Trump's pick for treasury secretary said he plans to divest from assets that could pose a conflict of interest. A16

THE REGION A company is buying up D.C. properties to convert them into "co-living" spaces for as many as 36 housemates. B1

Permitted protests surrounding this year's presidential inauguration are expected to be smaller than during other recent swearings-in, National Park Service inquiries show. B1
A report found a Virginia hospital was slow to report suspected abuse of infants. B1

STYLE Grady Hendrix has found mainstream success with vividly violent and surprisingly heart-felt horror novels. His most outlandish character might be himself. C1
A New Mexico home featured in "Breaking Bad" is listed for nearly \$4 million. C1

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